

tain sync works fine for most flash-photography. Rear curtain sync works quite well for stopping motion.

X sync

X-sync or Xenon Synchronisation works with the electronic flashes in typical digital cameras. The best part about X-sync is that xenon flashes respond more or less instantaneously. The timing of the contact, therefore, coincides exactly with the moment that the shutter is fully open, usually at a shutter speed of 1/60 or lower. Several cameras today, offer an X-sync speed as high as 1/500. If your camera has an electronic shutter, X-sync speeds can be significantly increased.

Cameras that offer faster sync speeds are neither better nor worse – they only give you more options to play with. Higher sync speeds help control the brightness of the background, while maintaining normal flash exposure in the foreground. If you have a camera which provides you with higher sync speeds, you could use a higher ISO or a larger aperture to maintain the same exposure to ambient light while increasing the sensitivity to the flash.

Faster sync speeds also allow you to move farther away from the subject and / or use less flash power, thereby augmenting battery life. For every single ‘stop’ increase in sync speed, you can open the aperture up by one f-stop because you now have a 30-40 per cent increase in range. However, for daily use and point-and-shoot purposes, the built-in flash in your camera is enough for fill and you needn’t bother fiddling around with the sync speed at all.

To summarise this section, sync speed has the most significant benefits for shots in daylight (due to the better fill) and stopping motion (due to the emphasis on the subject in the foreground).